YAZHI COMMONS · OPEN PROJECT

சங்கம்

Open Sangam

Classical Tamil poetry, open to everyone, and built together.

A free, open-source home for the eighteen works of Sangam literature: the original verse, modern Tamil prose, word notes and, with your help, careful English. Made for learners, teachers, scholars, developers and designers.

Learners · Teachers · Scholars · Developers · Designers · Funders

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யாதும் ஊரே யாவரும் கேளிர்

“Every town is our town; every person is our kin.” Kaṇiyaṉ Pūṅkuṉṟaṉār, Puṟanāṉūṟu 192 (our plain rendering)

sangam.yazhi.dev · github.com/yazhi-lem/open-sangam

சங்கத் தமிழ், எல்லோர்க்கும் திறந்த வாசல்

WHAT OPEN SANGAM IS

A reading room, a dataset and a workshop, all in the open

Open Sangam takes the poems of the Sangam age, now scattered across old websites and printed editions, and turns them into one clean, structured, openly licensed collection that anyone can read, study, reuse and improve.

For readers

A web reader at sangam.yazhi.dev where every verse can be read in layers: the original Sangam Tamil, a modern Tamil prose explanation (*urai*), and English where it exists. Click a word to see notes on it. Explore poems by landscape (*tiṇai*), by poet, or as a connected map of the whole corpus.

For builders and researchers

The same texts as structured data, organised poem → line → word, with the source of every record kept alongside it. That makes the corpus usable for search, teaching tools, linguistics and the careful evaluation of Tamil language technology.

For the community

A public workshop. The code is on GitHub under GPL-3.0. Corrections, translations and reviews are made in the open, so every change can be seen, discussed and credited.

In one sentence

Open Sangam is a shared, honest digital edition of classical Tamil that scholars review as we go, owned by no single company and free for everyone.

Who is behind it

Open Sangam is an open project of **Yazhi**, a collective of Indian-language developers based in Sivakasi, Tamil Nadu, who build open-source software from India, for India: Tamil first, other Indian languages next. Open Sangam belongs to the Commons. There is no paid edition and no paywall.

What you can do with it

Read

Move between the original verse and a modern prose explanation, line by line, on a phone or laptop.

Teach & learn

Open a poem in class, look up a word, and follow the five landscapes that shape Sangam poetry.

Build & study

Download structured text with source links for research, tools and fair tests of Tamil AI.

WHY SANGAM LITERATURE MATTERS

The oldest living voice of Tamil

Sangam poetry is the earliest body of Tamil literature that survives. It is commonly dated to roughly the first centuries BCE and CE (scholars differ on exact dates), and it still speaks plainly about love, war, generosity, grief and the land.

Eighteen works

Eṭṭuttokai, the Eight Anthologies: Naṟṟiṇai, Kuṟuntokai, Aiṅkuṟunūṟu, Patiṟṟuppattu, Paripāṭal, Kalittokai, Akanāṉūṟu and Puṟanāṉūṟu.

Pattuppāṭṭu, the Ten Idylls: Tirumurukāṟṟuppaṭai, Poruṇarāṟṟuppaṭai, Ciṟupāṇāṟṟuppaṭai, Perumpāṇāṟṟuppaṭai, Mullaippāṭṭu, Maturaikkāñci, Neṭunalvāṭai, Kuṟiñcippāṭṭu, Paṭṭiṉappālai and Malaipaṭukaṭām.

Together they are usually counted as about 2,381 poems by some 473 named and unnamed poets: women and men, court poets and wandering bards. Auvaiyār, Kapilar, Paraṇar and Nakkīrar are among the best known.

Inner and outer worlds

The poems are sorted into **akam** (the inner world of love) and **puṟam** (the outer world of kings, war, giving and death). Akam poems tie each human mood to a landscape, its season, flowers, birds and work. This is the *tiṇai* system, which the grammar *Tolkāppiyam* sets out in detail.

> தீதும் நன்றும் பிறர் தர வாரா
>
> *"Harm and good do not come to us from others."*
> *Puṟanāṉūṟu 192*

The five landscapes (tiṇai)

குறிஞ்சி
Kuṟiñci · mountains · lovers' union

முல்லை
Mullai · forest and pasture · patient waiting

மருதம்
Marutam · farmland · quarrel and sulking

நெய்தல்
Neytal · seashore · anxious longing

பாலை
Pālai · parched land · separation

For culture

These poems are where Tamil memory begins: place names, plants, music, food and the ethics of giving.

For language

They hold words and grammar that modern Tamil still draws on. Read closely, they show how the language works.

For the world

They are among the great classical literatures, and many people have never been able to read them in a form they can follow.

WHY TAMIL NEEDS THIS NOW

A rich literature with a thin digital footprint

Tamil has one of the deepest literary traditions in the world. Yet in software and AI it is still treated as a “low-resource” language. The reason is not a lack of literature. It is a lack of clean, structured, openly licensed digital text.

What readers face today

- **Scattered sources.** Classical texts sit on separate websites and in scanned books, each with its own layout, and with no stable way to cite a single line.
- **Hard to follow alone.** A student, or a Tamil reader abroad, often meets the verse without the help needed to read it: a prose explanation, word notes, the landscape behind the image.
- **Unclear rights.** The ancient poems are public domain, but modern commentaries and translations are not, and websites rarely say what may be reused.
- **Hidden errors.** Missing lines, mixed spellings and inconsistent Unicode make search and study unreliable. We have found all of these in our own data and are fixing them in the open.

Why now

- **Machines are writing Tamil.** More and more Tamil on the web is produced by translation systems and chatbots. Without a carefully kept human reference, it gets harder to tell good Tamil from fluent-sounding mistakes.
- **Scholarship is ageing.** The people who can read these poems closely, our *pulavar* and *ayya*, carry knowledge that is not yet in any open, searchable form.
- **Learning has moved to phones.** If classical Tamil is not good on a phone screen, a generation will simply not meet it.

What Open Sangam changes

One place, one structure, one open licence for the code, a source link on every record, and a public record of every correction. The work is slow and careful, so we do it together.

> “Low-resource” is not a fact about Tamil. It is a fact about what has been digitised, cleaned and shared. That part we can change.

WHY AI TECHNOLOGY NEEDS IT

Good Tamil AI starts with good Tamil data

Language technology learns from text. If the Tamil it learns from is scarce, messy or machine-made, the tools that come out will be poor at Tamil. Open Sangam is one small, careful contribution to fixing that at the root.

1 Clean, open data with provenance

Each record keeps its source link, and machine drafts are marked `verified: false` with a note of how they were made. Anyone can see what a model is learning from, and can leave out what is not yet trustworthy.

2 Tokenisation that respects Tamil

Tamil builds long words from many parts, and its letters are clusters of Unicode code points. Tokenisers built mostly for English break Tamil words into many small pieces. Normalised, well-formed classical text helps people build and test tokenisers that keep Tamil letters and word parts whole.

3 Honest evaluation

A model that "knows Tamil" should be able to quote a verse correctly and say where it comes from. A stable, citable corpus lets us check that. Our Avai project, now in development, is built on one rule: answer with a cited verse, or say "I don't know."

4 Keeping machine text out of the record

When AI text is fed back into AI, quality drifts and errors become "facts". We keep human-reviewed text and machine drafts clearly apart and labelled, so the human record stays clean and drafts can be replaced later.

5 Self-reliance (தற்சார்பு)

Tamil's classical heritage should not depend on one platform or one foreign provider. An open corpus under a public licence, which anyone can copy, host in India and build on, keeps that heritage in the community's hands.

What it is not

On its own, the Sangam corpus is far too small to train a general Tamil model, and we do not claim it is. Its value is as a carefully kept, gold-standard reference for the classical register: for testing, for grounding answers, and for teaching.

யாவரும்

யா வ ரு ம்

A small example

yāvarum, "everyone", from Puṟanāṉūṟu 192. A reader sees 4 letters. Underneath are 7 Unicode code points (`U+0BAF U+0BBE U+0BB5 U+0BB0 U+0BC1 U+0BAE U+0BCD`) and 21 bytes of UTF-8. A tokeniser that cuts between code points or bytes can split a single Tamil letter in two.

WHAT EXISTS TODAY · CHECKED 18 OCTOBER 2026

Where we honestly stand

These figures come from a count of the public repository on 18 October 2026. Some older pages still show earlier figures, which we are correcting.

18
Sangam works in the corpus: all 8 anthologies and all 10 idylls

2,669
records, including 5 placeholders for songs not available in the source

99.4%
of records (2,653) carry a modern Tamil prose explanation (urai)

0
records signed off by a scholar so far. This is the work ahead.

Records per work

WORK	RECORDS	WORK	RECORDS
Aiṅkuṟunūṟu	500	Maturaikkāñci	63
Akanāṉūṟu	400	Malaipaṭukaṭām	45
Kuṟuntokai	400	Perumpāṇāṟṟuppaṭai	41
Naṟṟiṇai	400	Tirumurukāṟṟuppaṭai	32
Puṟanāṉūṟu	400	Paṭṭiṉappālai	30
Kalittokai	149	Kuṟiñcippāṭṭu	25
Patiṟṟuppattu	80	Ciṟupāṇāṟṟuppaṭai	25
Paripāṭal	23	Poruṇarāṟṟuppaṭai	21
		Mullaippāṭṭu	18
		Neṭunalvāṭai	17

The ten idylls are stored in sections, so their record counts are sections, not poems.

In the reader

- LIVE Layered view: Sangam Tamil · modern Tamil prose · English
- LIVE Click-to-define word notes, the *Sangam World* landscape explorer, a knowledge guide, a connections graph of poems, poets and landscapes, and articles
- IN DEVELOPMENT Sangam Avai: Tamil questions answered with cited verses

Drafts and gaps, said plainly

- MACHINE DRAFT English exists for only 32 records (Tirumurukāṟṟuppaṭai). All 32 are unreviewed machine drafts. There is **no human English translation yet**.
- MACHINE DRAFT Word notes (root, etymology, gloss) on 528 records, plus 32 modern Tamil drafts, were machine-generated and await review. We are labelling unreviewed text as a draft in the reader.
- GAP The idylls have missing lines, about 1,225 across 93 sections, because the source pages are incomplete. We are documenting them.
- OPEN The prose explanations come from sangathamizh.com and are credited to it. Their reuse terms are still to be confirmed with the source.

Licences: code GPL-3.0 · the ancient verses are public domain · source link kept on every record.

HOW IT WORKS AND WHAT WE STAND FOR

Machines can help draft. People decide what is true.

Every verse moves through the same open path. Nothing is called “verified” until a person who knows the text has read it and signed it off.

1 · Source
Public-domain verse is collected and its source link is kept on the record.

2 · Structure
Text is cleaned, Unicode-normalised and stored poem → line → word.

3 · Draft
Helpers, human or machine, may draft prose or notes. Drafts are marked unverified, with how they were made.

4 · Review
A Tamil scholar checks line by line. On approval the record is marked verified and the reviewer is named.

5 · Publish
The reader and the open data update together. Changes are versioned and nothing is silently deleted.

Our principles

Open source, open process
The code is GPL-3.0 on GitHub. Discussion, review and history are public. Anyone may copy, study, self-host and improve it.

Scholars first
Tamil scholars, our *pulavar* and *ayya*, have the final word on meaning. AI speeds up the work. It never certifies it.

Attribution, always
Every source keeps its credit. Every reviewer, translator and contributor is named for their work, and reuse rights are respected before anything is published.

Free, with no ads
Reading is free and needs no login. There are no ads and we do not sell readers’ data. Open Sangam is a Commons project, with no paid edition.

Honest labels
Draft means draft. Missing lines are shown as missing. When a number changes, we correct it in public.

Tamil first
Tamil is the starting point, not a translation layer added at the end. English comes second, as its own careful work.

HOW EVERYONE CAN CONTRIBUTE

There is a first task for you

If you can read a line of Tamil, write a line of code, draw, teach or support the work, you can help. Language work counts as much as code.

Developers

React and Vite on the front end, Python for the data pipeline, JSON for the corpus.

First tasks: Unicode-normalise (NFC) the 113 idyll records with split vowel signs · unify the `title` / `heading` field names · mark the 5 placeholder records as "not available" and leave them out of counts.

Scholars, pulavar and ayya

Your reading is what turns a draft into a trusted text.

First tasks: review Maduraikkāñci lines 1–100 line by line · add the missing headings and poets for Puṟanāṉūṟu · help find a reliable edition for the idylls' missing lines.

Translators

There is no human English translation in the corpus yet. Your work would be the first.

First tasks: translate one short Kuṟuntokai poem with brief notes · review one of the 32 machine English drafts and mark what is wrong.

Designers

Help classical Tamil look and read beautifully on small screens.

First tasks: tiṇai illustrations and icons · mobile reading layouts in Noto Sans Tamil, with no letter-spacing · print and social templates for teachers.

Teachers

You know what students struggle with. Tell us.

First tasks: use one poem in a class and send us notes on what helped and what confused · suggest the words that most need explaining · share a lesson idea we can publish openly.

Donors and funders

Careful scholarship takes paid time.

Where support goes: honoraria for scholar review · licence-cleared source editions · India-based hosting. Talk to us first, and we will tell you plainly what your support will pay for.

New to open source? Start with a GitHub issue or the contribution page. Tell us what you know, and we will match you with a task.

JOIN US

Let us build it together

The Sangam poets wrote for everyone who would listen. Two thousand years later, keeping their words whole, correct and open is work no single person or company can do alone. It needs all of us.

Contribute
sangam.yazhi.dev/contribution
Tell us how you would like to help.

Code and data
github.com/yazhi-lem/open-sangam
Read the code, open an issue, send a pull request.

Three things you can do today

- Read a poem at **sangam.yazhi.dev** and tell us one thing that should be better.
- Pick a first task from page 8 and open an issue saying you are on it.
- Share this brochure with one teacher, one scholar and one developer you know.

Yazhi · From India, for India. In your language first.

Open Sangam is a Yazhi Commons project. Code GPL-3.0. Free to read, with no ads.